VERA ZHENG

User Researcher · UIUX Designer

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PROFILE SUMMARY

User Researcher and UIUX Designer with hands-on experience leading mixed-methods research (usability testing, user interviews, surveys) within financial services. Skilled at synthesizing qualitative and quantitative data into journey maps, personas, and prioritized recommendations that directly inform product decisions. Proven ability to bridge user insights with business goals, partnering with Product, Engineering, and Design teams to drive user-centered outcomes. Proficient in Figma, Maze, Tableau, and Excel, with a foundation in design thinking, information architecture, and WCAG accessibility.

EDUCATION

- **University of Toronto** **Sept 2024 – July 2026**

Master of Information, User Experience Design | 3.9 / 4.0 *Toronto, Ontario, Canada*

- **University of Alberta** **Sept 2020 – Apr 2024**

Bachelor of Commerce, Major in Finance with distinction | 3.75 / 4.0 *Edmonton, Alberta, Canada*

Achievement: Undergraduate Scholarship (2021). TSX Group Scholarship in Finance, Yuichi Kurimoto Memorial Award (2022). TSX Group Scholarship in Finance – Renewal (2023).

WORK EXPERIENCE

Royal Bank of Canada (RBC) – Online Banking **Jan 2026 – Apr 2026**

Design Researcher Intern *Toronto, Ontario, Canada*

- Led end-to-end usability testing with 28 participants (A/B testing and task-based evaluations) within a tight 3-week cycle, building discussion guides, configuring Maze studies, translating findings into prioritized recommendations that informed UI, interaction, and workflow improvements. Presented insights to stakeholders to support design decisions.
- Designed and launched digital banking surveys (n=250) using MaxDiff methodology and behavioral questions to establish trackable UX metrics, enabling the team to benchmark user satisfaction and measure the impact of future design iterations.
- Conducted strategic generative research to build user personas and visualize end-to-end user journeys for Online Banking Team, mapping pain points across touchpoints and directly informing the product design direction for multiple squads. Applied qualitative coding and quantitative analysis to synthesize research into clear, actionable design recommendations.
- Moderated 11 one-on-one sessions with RBC clients, translating qualitative feedback into actionable design and interaction requirements that reduced friction points in core banking workflows.

Royal Bank of Canada (RBC) – Online Banking **May 2025 – Aug 2025**

Design Researcher Intern *Toronto, Ontario, Canada*

- Led a moderated usability study via Maze with 10 participants to evaluate KONEK (a Canadian digital P2P payment platform), uncovering critical usability issues within the app's entry point and core flow that had previously been overlooked by the product team.
- Conducted usability testing with 9 participants on RBC Online Banking's e-Transfer transaction download experience, evaluating self-service effectiveness and identifying usability barriers related to system feedback and in-product assistance; collaborated with Product Designers, PMs, and Engineers to translate findings into actionable design recommendations aligned with business goals.
- Synthesized research findings into visual narratives using Figma and PowerPoint, communicating user pain points and design recommendations to cross-functional stakeholders to build alignment on proposed changes.

Easy Education Inc. **Dec 2024 – Aug 2025**

Finance Instructor *Toronto, Ontario, Canada*

- Delivered interactive lectures on corporate finance, stock analysis, excel operation to undergraduate students.

- Broke down complex financial concepts (e.g., NPV, options pricing, risk-return trade-offs, data analysis) into simplified, digestible learning modules, demonstrating the ability to translate complexity into clarity.
- Designed structured course materials and practice problems that improved student problem-solving accuracy, demonstrating ability to identify knowledge gaps and deliver targeted solutions.

PROJECT & LEADERSHIP EXPERIENCE

MaaTRx — Drug Shortage Platform Redesign **March 2026**

- Redesigned the core entry point (SynapseRx) of a subscription-based B2B SaaS platform for drug shortage management, engaging directly with real healthcare clients to gather feedback and validate design decisions.
- Conducted a brand refresh to establish consistent visual language and scalable UI components, reducing visual inconsistency and creating a more professional user experience.
- Restructured content architecture and information hierarchy to improve navigation, reducing user frustration and enabling healthcare clients to access critical information more efficiently.
- Portfolio: verazhengdesign.github.io/work/maatrx.html

Weavy - Human-Centered Friend Matching App (2026 U of T Designthon) **Feb 2026**

- Conducted open-ended surveys with target users, mapped behavior patterns, and created user personas to identify core pain points in existing social connection platforms.
- Designed complete end-to-end UI logic, from initial sketches and user flows to 27 high-fidelity interactive screens in Figma within 24 hours, demonstrating ability to move rapidly from research to validated design.
- Presented research findings and design prototype to hackathon judges and industry professionals, effectively communicating design rationale and user impact under tight timelines.
- Portfolio: verazhengdesign.github.io/work/weavy.html

ReBites - 2025 Seneca Hackathon (1st Place Winner) **Mar 2025**

- Co-led design of a gamified learning platform for young children to promote food sustainability, conducting usability testing with 24 education-sector participants through surveys to validate core assumptions.
- Created user personas, journey maps, and a high-fidelity prototype, incorporating rapid testing feedback within a 48-hour cycle to continuously refine the user experience.
- Presented findings in a compelling story format to judges, emphasizing design rationale and user impact: Winning 1st Place for innovation and feasibility.
- Portfolio: verazhengdesign.github.io/work/rebites.html

LemonWise - Student Financial Management Project **Sept 2024 – Dec 2024**

- Conducted in-depth user interviews and affinity mapping with students to uncover behavioral patterns and pain points in managing personal finances across multi-platform banking tools, identifying a clear gap between student financial literacy and existing solutions.
- Synthesized research into User Personas, Journey Maps, and Service Blueprints, mapping the end-to-end service experience to ensure design alignment with real-world user constraints.
- Translated qualitative insights into a clear product value proposition, identifying key differentiators that bridged the gap between student needs and existing banking tool complexities.
- Articulated research-backed design decisions through visual storytelling, ensuring the final concept directly addressed the core mission of improving student financial well-being.
- Portfolio: verazhengdesign.github.io/work/lemonwise.html

SKILLS & CERTIFICATIONS

- **Research & Analysis:** User Interviews, Usability Testing (Moderated & Unmoderated), Survey Design (MaxDiff), Mixed-Methods Research, Data Synthesis, Behavioral Analysis, Card Sorting, Tree Testing, Journey Mapping
- **Design & Tools:** Figma, Wireframing, Prototyping, Interaction Design, Information Architecture, Design Systems, Accessibility (WCAG), Service Design, Maze, Alida, Tableau, Excel, UserTesting
- **Certifications:** Google Data Analytics (2024), Japanese-Language Proficiency Test N1 (2024)
- **Personal Website**: https://verazhengdesign.github.io/